The AI ROI Benchmarking Study 2025

Highlights Report:

Real Numbers from Real Practitioners

Superintelligent & AIDB Intelligence | December 2025

An analysis of 5,124 AI use cases from 1,245 practitioners across industries, revealing the measurable impact of artificial intelligence in the enterprise.

Foreword

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Three years into the generative AI era, we've reached an inflection point. The question is no longer "should we be using AI?" but "what is AI actually doing for us?"

As the host of the AI Daily Brief and CEO of Superintelligent, I've watched this shift in real time. Throughout 2024 and into 2025, conversations with enterprise leaders changed dramatically. Early on, the focus was experimentation—getting people to try the tools, launching pilots, building excitement. Now, leadership teams and boards are asking harder questions: What's the tangible value? Is the investment justified?

These questions arrive at a noisy moment. Headlines about an "AI bubble" dominate, and while those concerns center on market dynamics, they inevitably bleed into narratives about whether AI delivers real enterprise value. You've likely encountered the claim that "95% of AI pilots fail"—a statistic that, while catchy, doesn't hold up to scrutiny.

Here's the challenge: when companies try to answer the ROI question, they find remarkably little to work with. No agreed-upon methodology. Most available benchmarks come from vendor marketing or vendor-funded research. The result is a vacuum, and into it flows breathless hype, reflexive skepticism, and not much actual data.

I believe 2026 will be the year this changes—not through a universal standard, but through practice. Companies will start measuring whatever they can, tracking productivity gains and translating them to organizational impact. The discipline of AI ROI measurement will emerge through doing, not prescription.

This survey is our contribution to that emerging discipline. We asked our audience—AI practitioners, builders, and leaders—to share use cases and quantify their impact. The response exceeded expectations: over 5,000 use cases with ROI data attached.

I want to be clear: this isn't a peer-reviewed academic exercise. Respondents are self-selected; data is self-reported. But the picture that emerges is striking in its clarity: AI is delivering measurable value now, across a wide range of applications, and that value is growing as organizations mature.

What you'll find here isn't a counterargument to the hype, it's something better: **Real numbers from real practitioners doing real work.**

Methodology Overview

The survey, conducted during October–November 2025, was voluntary and open to anyone using AI at work. Respondents could list as many use cases as they wanted and self-attest to the ROI they experience personally and at a company level.

Survey Period

October–November 2025

Total Respondents

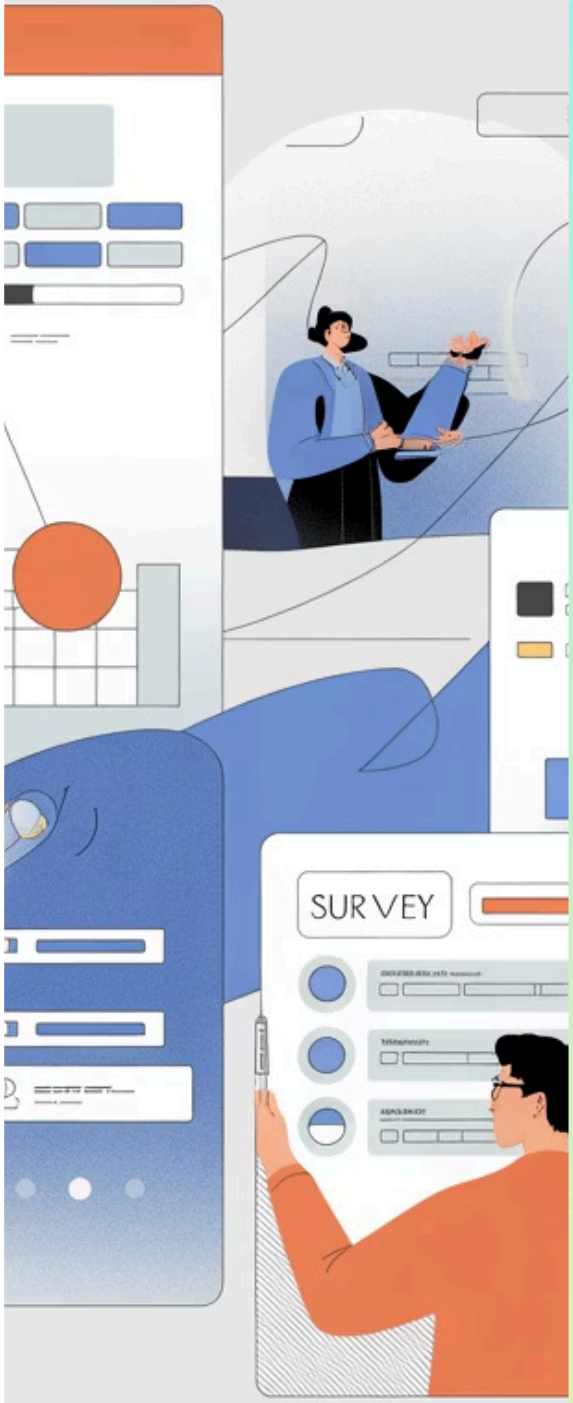
1,245 participants

Use Cases Collected

5,124 individual cases

Response Type

Self-reported data



Data Collection Structure

Use Case Level Benefits

At the use case level, respondents described specific implementations and selected the primary benefit from eight categories:

- **Time saving: Saved hours per week**
- **Cost saving: Cost reduction in percentage**
- **Increased output/throughput: Increase in output in percentage**
- **Quality improvement: Quality improvement in percentage**
- **Increased revenue: Revenue impact in percentage**
- **New capabilities: Description of new capabilities**
- **Risk reduction: Description of reduced risk**
- **Improved decision making: Improvement in decision quality/speed in percentage**

Company Level Impact

At the company level, users identified all areas of impact valuable to them from the comprehensive benefit categories.

ROI Scoring System

Respondents estimated overall ROI from personal usage across five categories, translated into a 5-point scale:

1. **Negative ROI**
2. **Break-even**
3. **Modestly positive**
4. **Significantly positive**
5. **Transformational**

Sample Demographics

351

Technology Sector

Largest industry segment

536

Small Companies

Respondents from 1-50 employees

113

Average per Industry

Mean respondents per sector

Industry Distribution

Our survey captured perspectives from eleven major industries: Technology, Professional Services, Financial Services, Education, Healthcare, Manufacturing, Retail/E-commerce, Government/Public Sector, Media/Entertainment, Energy, and Other. This diversity ensures our findings reflect AI adoption patterns across the full spectrum of business operations.

Company Size Clustering

Respondents were grouped into five segments based on employee count: 1–50, 51–200, 201–1,000, 1,001–5,000, and 5,000+. The largest segment comprised small companies (1–50 employees) with 536 respondents, while mid-sized organizations (1,001–5,000 employees) represented the smallest segment with 139 respondents. This distribution provides robust insights into how AI ROI varies with organizational scale.

Role Level Distribution

Participants self-identified across six role categories: C-level (Founder), VP, Director, Manager, Individual Contributor, or Other. Each category had between 107 and 397 respondents, ensuring representation from strategic decision-makers to hands-on practitioners implementing AI solutions daily.

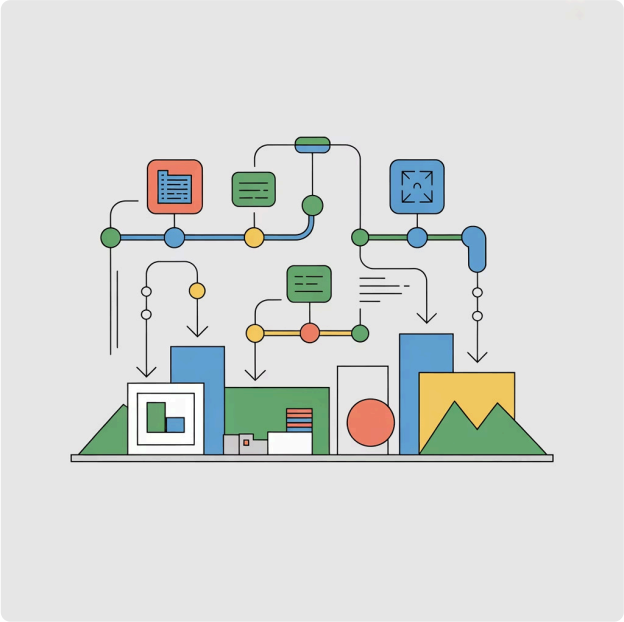
Limitations and Analysis Process

Understanding the Biases

This dataset represents a broad industry testimonial rather than a controlled study. While the numbers are substantial, not every data slice is statistically significant. Key biases include:

- **Self-selection bias:** Survey respondents likely skew toward AI-engaged users
- **Small business effect:** Approximately 25% of the sample (solopreneurs and executives of small companies) may inflate overall numbers due to the high efficiency of agile operators
- **Perception vs. measurement:** ROI is self-reported, not calculated via audit
- **Snapshot in time:** Anticipated ROI reflects expectations, not guarantees

Regardless of these potential biases, the distribution across roles, company sizes, and industries is strong enough to yield solid, useful overall patterns.



Rigorous Analysis Methodology

The raw data was cleaned and reviewed manually by our analysts. Following an additional anomaly-removal step, we ran a hybrid and iterative process involving human review and AI tools analysis.

A wide range of AI tools were utilized, including Claude 4.5 Opus, Gemini 3 Pro, NotebookLM, OpenAI Deep Research, GPT5.1 Thinking and Pro, Manus, GenSpark, and Gamma. A human expert double-checked every letter and number presented in this report.

The goal is to provide early, evidence-based visibility into how AI is delivering value today and to spark a wider conversation on the real ROI companies are seeing.

Key Insights at a Glance

The ROI Question is Clear

The debate on "does it work?" is over. **81.8%** of companies report positive ROI today, and **95.7%** expect it within 12 months.

The "Small Business" Advantage

Agility is winning. Small companies (1–50 employees) report significantly higher ROI (**3.49/5** - half-way between "modest" and "significant") compared to large enterprises (**2.94/5** - just under "modest").

The Efficiency Trap

While **77%** of companies cite "Time Savings" as a benefit, those who focus only on time savings report lower ROI. The highest value comes from strategic benefits like Decision Making and New Capabilities.

Public Sector & Media Lead the Pack

Contrary to stereotypes, Government/Public Sector, Education, and Media are reporting 2-3x higher composite benefits than regulation-heavy sectors like Finance and Healthcare.

"Agents" are Still Nascent

While **13.8%** of use cases claim to be autonomous agents, the dominant mode for the moment remains Assisted AI (**56.6%**). Notably, small to mid-sized companies (51-200 employees) are currently the "sweet spot" for automation.

Generic Tools, Generic Results

Organizations relying solely on general LLMs (ChatGPT/Claude) mostly see efficiency gains. Those achieving transformational ROI (Revenue/Cost) are integrating specific tools into workflows.

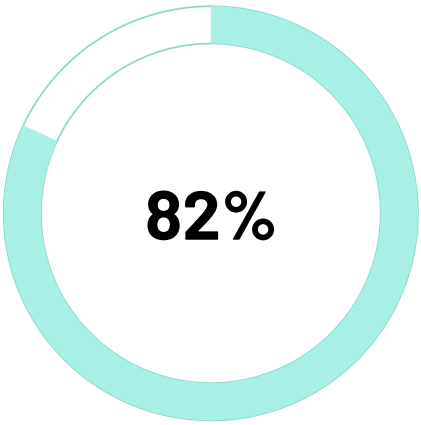
Report Structure

In the remainder of the document, we go deeper into the AI ROI Highlights looking at 9 Key Patterns. We start by highlighting the most interesting finding at the company level. Then we highlight the key insights of ROI at the use case level. For a full set of results and findings we refer the readers to the comprehensive results report.

1. High Momentum: Value is Realized and Accelerating

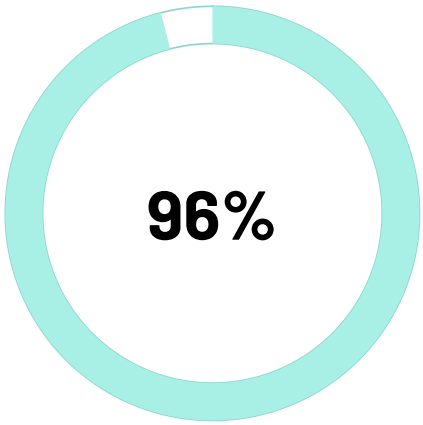
When asked about overall ROI in their company, participants are getting from AI, the clear theme was: Organizations aren't just seeing value—they expect it to accelerate. Currently, 81.8% of respondents, across all company sizes, roles and sectors report positive ROI (above "breakeven"), and this momentum is intensifying, with 95.7% anticipating positive ROI within the next 12 months.

Furthermore, the magnitude of impact is scaling: while the current median is "Modest" return, the median expectation for next year jumps to "Significant" return. Our interpretation: The initial investment phase is complete, and organizations are now forecasting compounding returns.



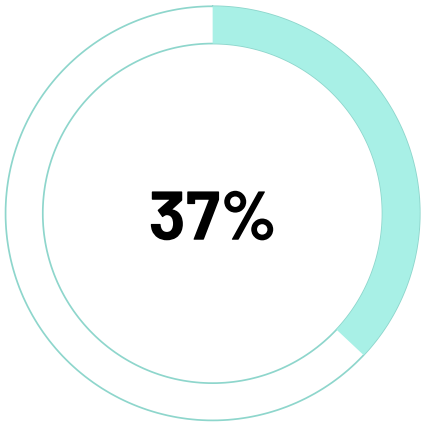
Current Positive ROI

Companies reporting above breakeven



Anticipated Positive ROI

Expected within 12 months

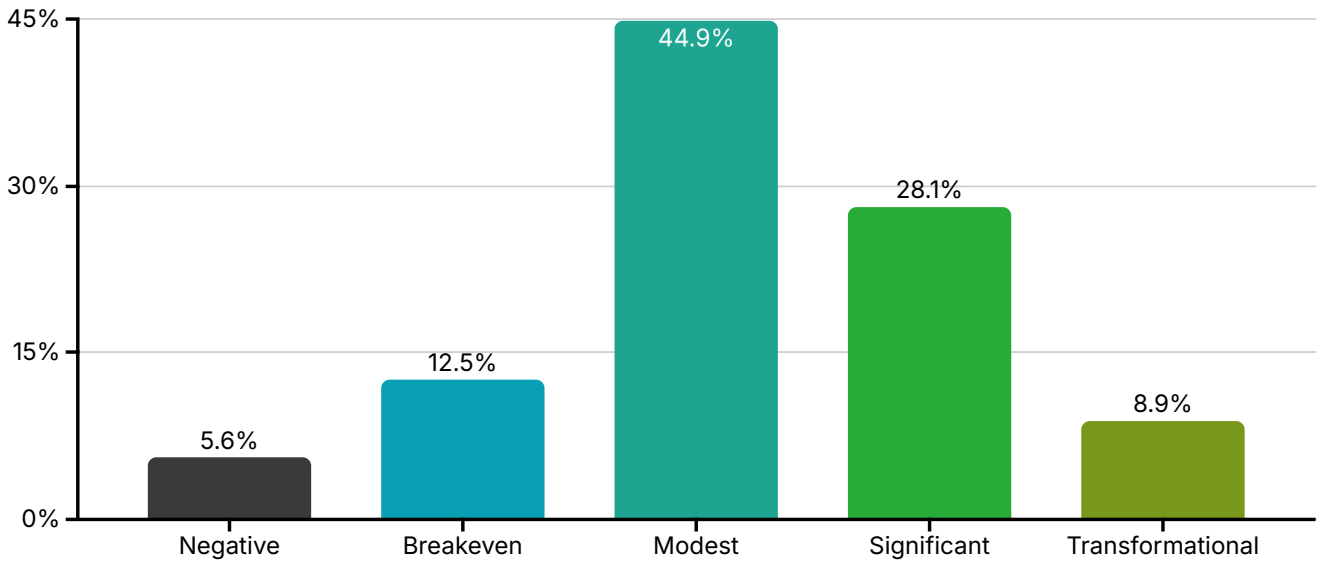


High ROI

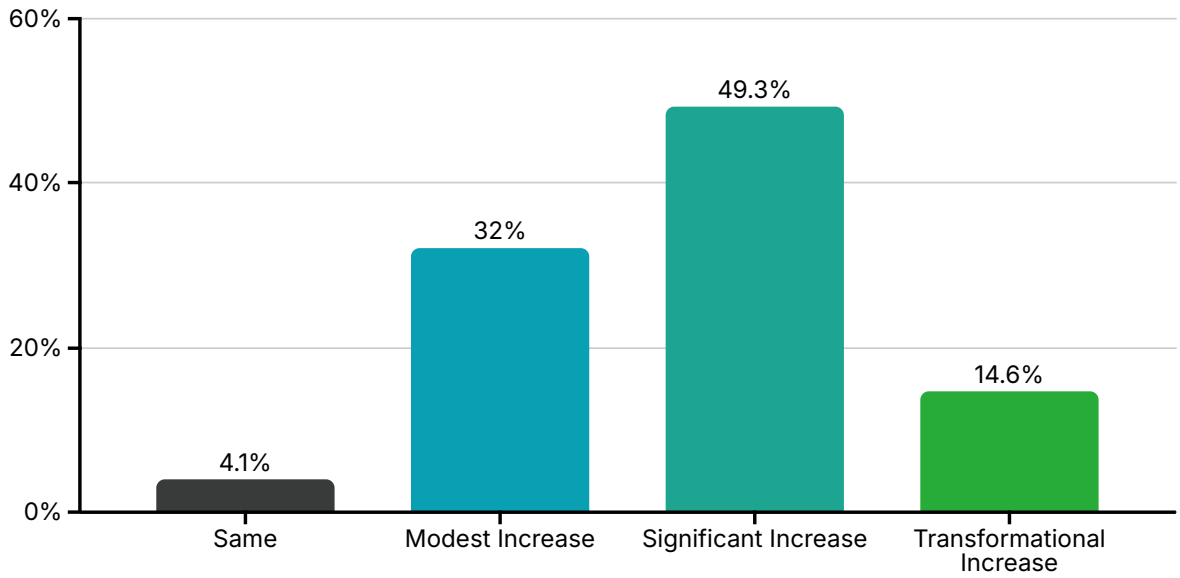
Currently reporting "Significant" or "Transformational"

Current vs. Anticipated ROI Distribution

Current ROI Distribution



Anticipated ROI Distribution



Future expectations are dramatically more optimistic: 49.3% anticipate significant increases, while 14.6% expect transformational growth. Only 4.1% expect returns to remain the same.

The current state shows 44.9% reporting modest returns, with 28.1% already experiencing significant impact. Only 5.6% report negative ROI.

> The shift from current to anticipated ROI represents one of the most compelling findings in our research—organizations that have invested in AI are doubling down with confidence.

2. Size Does Matter: The Small Company Advantage

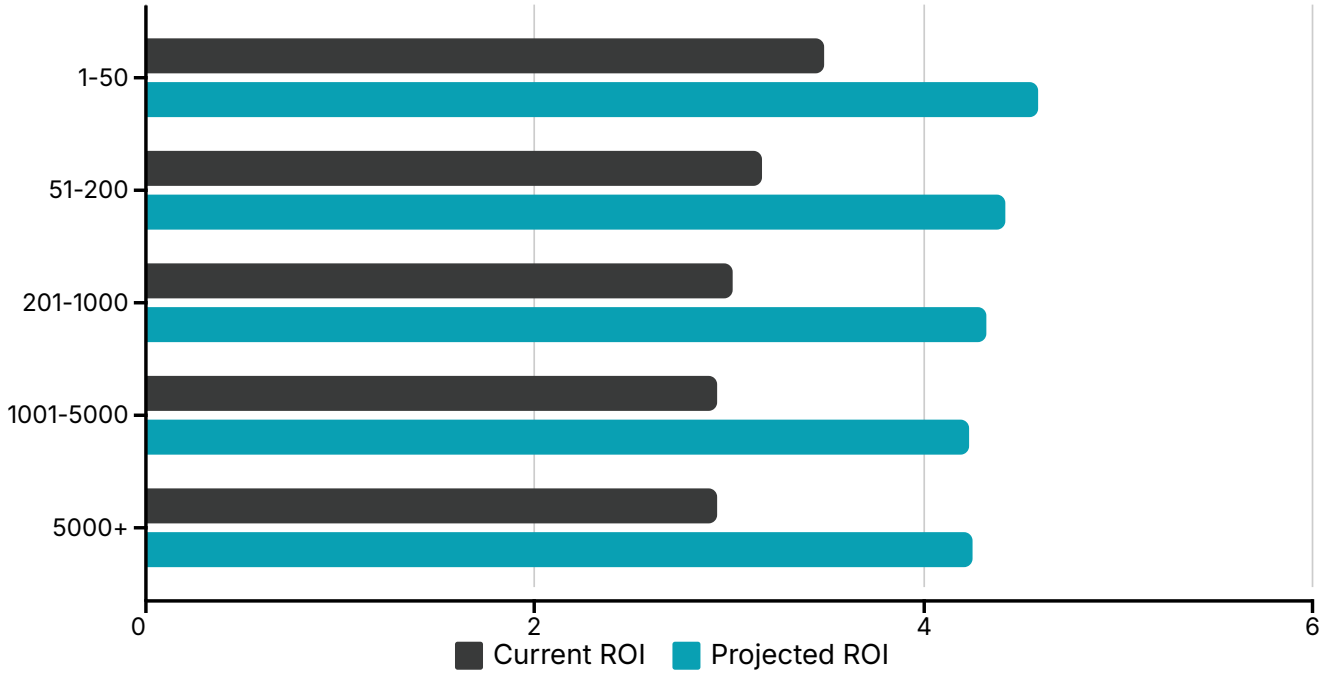
When comparing the current and projected ROI testimonials between participants from different organization sizes, there is a stark divide in ROI. Small companies (1–50 employees) report significantly higher ROI (Mean: 3.49/5) compared to large enterprises (Mean: 2.94/5).

This finding reveals a clear inverse relationship: smaller organizations consistently achieve better ROI from AI investments. The data suggests that organizational agility, fewer bureaucratic constraints, and closer alignment between decision-makers and implementers create substantial advantages for smaller companies.

Company Size	Current ROI	Projected ROI	Expected Jump
1-50	3.49	4.59	+1.83
51-200	3.17	4.42	+1.70
201-1,000	3.02	4.32	+1.65
1,001-5,000	2.94	4.23	+1.68
5,000+	2.94	4.25	+1.69

Analyzing the Size-ROI Relationship

Company size vs. current and projected ROI:



Small Companies Dominate

71% of companies with 1-50 employees project transformational ROI versus only 53% at enterprises with 5,000+

The "High ROI" Gap

91% of small companies expect Significant+ ROI compared to 78% at large enterprises

Starting Points Differ

Small companies already at 3.49 current ROI versus 2.94 for enterprises, a 19% advantage

Universal Optimism

Expected jump is ~1.7 levels across all sizes, enterprises aren't less optimistic, they're just starting lower

The implications are profound: larger organizations face structural challenges in AI adoption that require deliberate strategy to overcome. Meanwhile, smaller organizations should leverage their natural advantages while they can.

3. Time Savings: The Universal Entry Point

We asked the participants to select all the types of key benefits they're getting from AI (multiple choice) at an overall company level. The results reveal that 76.7% of participants cite Time Savings as a primary benefit—nearly 2x the next closest category. It is the dominant benefit across every single industry, role, and company size. It is the low-hanging fruit of the AI era: easy to implement, easy to feel, and easy to measure.

The Efficiency Trio Dominates

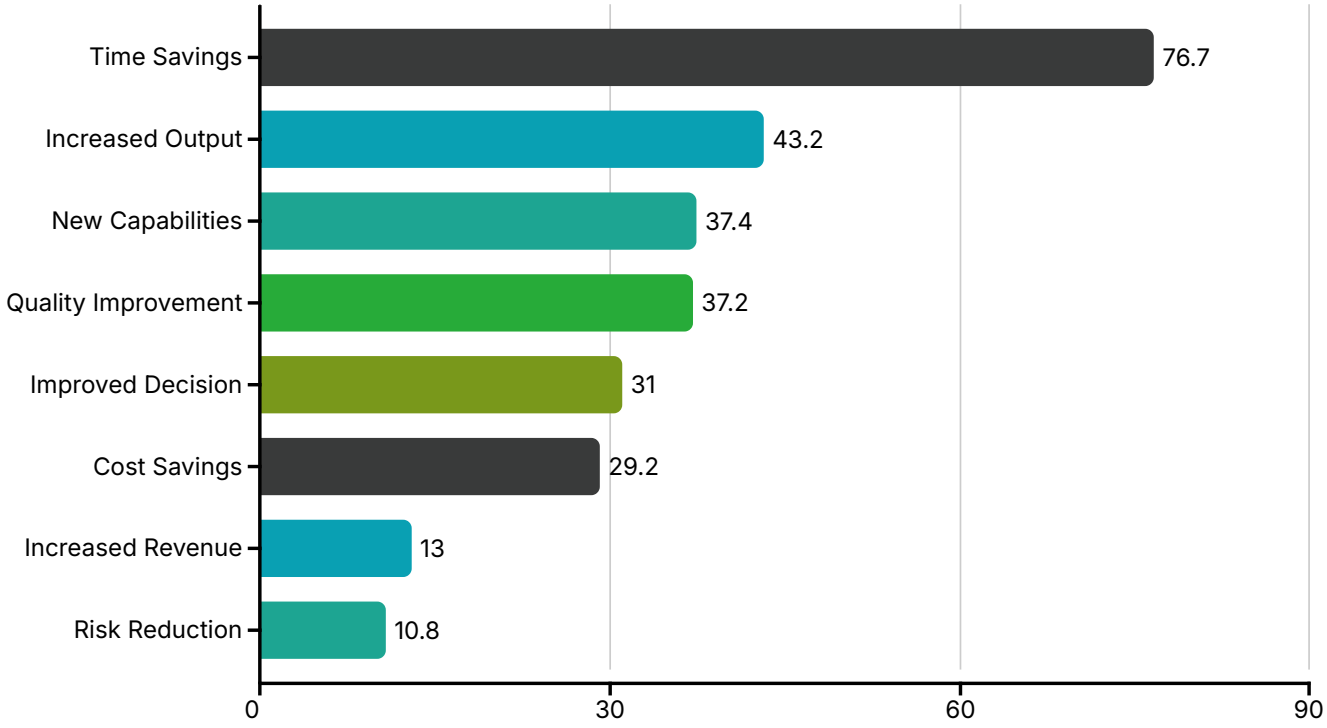
Time Savings + Increased Output + Quality Improvement cluster together (~37-43% each). This is the "productivity story" in action—organizations are using AI to do more, better, faster. However, as we'll explore in the next section, focusing solely on efficiency may not be the path to transformational returns.

Multi-Benefit is the Norm

69% of respondents selected 2 or more benefits, suggesting AI delivers compounding value across multiple dimensions. Organizations that successfully implement AI aren't seeing isolated improvements—they're experiencing cascading effects that touch multiple aspects of their operations.

77%	2.79	69%
Time Savings	**Average Benefits**	**Multi-Benefit Users**
Cite as primary benefit	Per participant reported	Selected 2+ categories

Company-Level Benefits Distribution



Key Observations

- **Total selections: 3,468 across 1,245 participants**
- **Average benefits per person: 2.79**
- **Revenue & Risk lag behind at only ~11-13%**
- **Perhaps harder to measure/attribute directly to AI**
- **Could indicate high focus on productivity over growth use cases**

4. To Win, You Must Move Upstream and Diversify

While Time Savings is the most common benefit, it is not the most valuable. Our data shows a crucial inverse correlation: respondents who only focus on Time Savings report lower overall ROI. Conversely, "strategic" benefits—Improved Decision Making, New Capabilities, and Increased Revenue—are significantly associated with higher ROI scores.

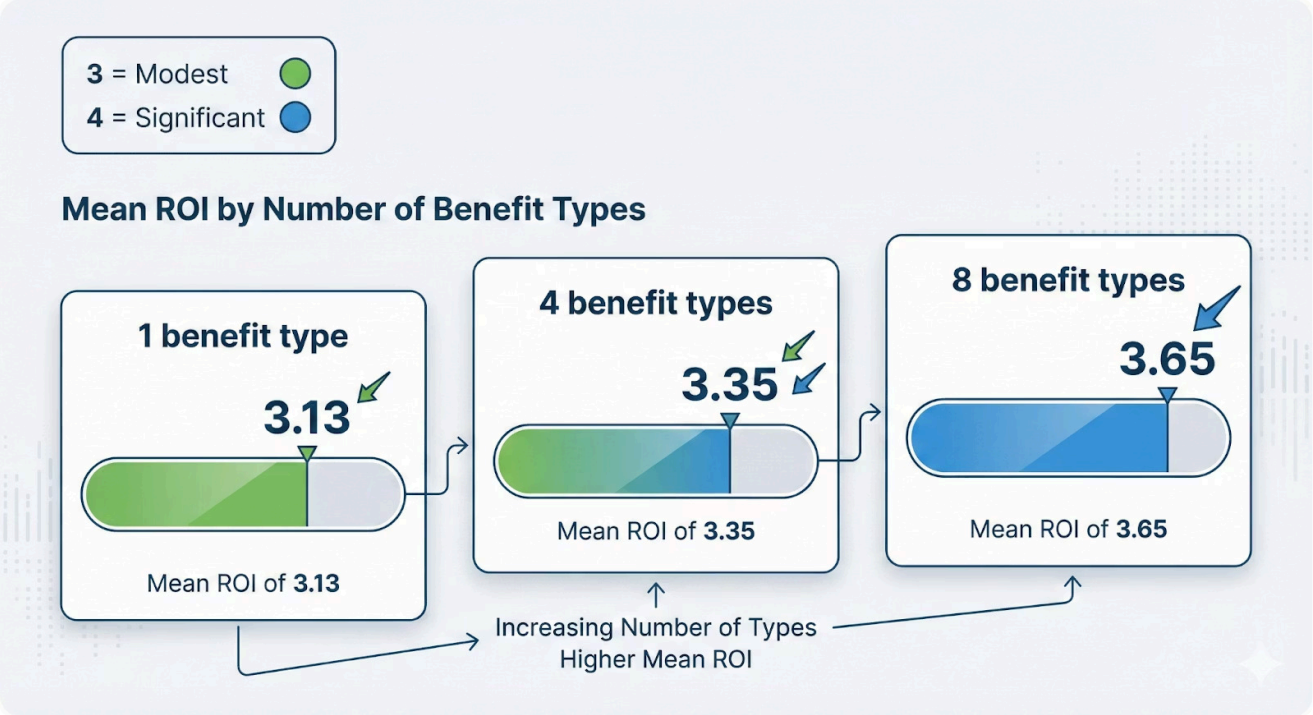
> Organizations treating AI as a faster typewriter get incremental gains. Organizations using AI to do things they couldn't do before get transformational gains.

Benefit Type	Current ROI Lift	Anticipated ROI Lift
Improved Decision Making	+0.20	+0.22
New Capabilities	+0.21	+0.12
Increased Output	+0.13	+0.13
Increased Revenue	—	+0.25
Cost Savings	—	+0.13

The "strategic" benefits (decision making, new capabilities, revenue) show stronger ROI correlation than the "operational" ones (time savings, quality). Organizations should ask: *"Are we using AI to do the same things faster, or to do new things?"*

This is the "growth ROI vs. Efficiency ROI" claim in action, which was repeatedly mentioned in the AI Daily Brief.

The Portfolio Effect: Breadth Drives Returns



In addition to moving upstream strategically, breadth of adoption matters significantly. We found a consistent correlation between the number of benefit categories a user experiences and their overall ROI. Participants citing 7–8 distinct benefits reported significantly higher ROI (Mean: ~3.6) compared to those citing just one (Mean: 3.1).

1	2	3
Single Use Case Pilots	**Expanded Implementation**	**Portfolio Approach**
Limited to one benefit category, typically time savings	2-4 benefit categories as AI spreads across teams	5+ categories indicating enterprise-wide transformation

Successful organizations are moving beyond single-use-case pilots to a portfolio approach. The compounding effect of multiple AI implementations across different business functions creates exponentially greater value than isolated experiments.

Items 5-9 highlight the key findings at the **Use Case Level.**

5. Use Case Analysis: Time Savings Dominates

Using the 5,124 individual use cases, we dug deeper into insights about per-use case benefits. Note that at the use case level, participants had to choose one primary benefit. After 5% outlier removal, clear patterns emerged about how organizations are deploying AI.

Time Savings represents more than one-third of all use cases (34.3%), with a cleaned average of 7.5 hours per week saved. This translates to approximately 20% of a typical work week—a substantial productivity gain that compounds across an organization.

Time Savings

34.3% of cases

7.5 hours/week average

Quality Improvement

15.0% of cases

38% average improvement

Increased Output

14.2% of cases

41% average increase

New Capabilities

12.4% of cases

Qualitative benefits

Consistent Improvement Patterns

Percentage-based benefits cluster around 30-40% improvement across Quality, Output, Decisions, and Cost categories. This consistency suggests AI delivers predictable value once properly implemented. Revenue impact is more modest at 19% average—likely because it's harder to directly attribute or because respondents were more conservative when estimating hard dollar figures.

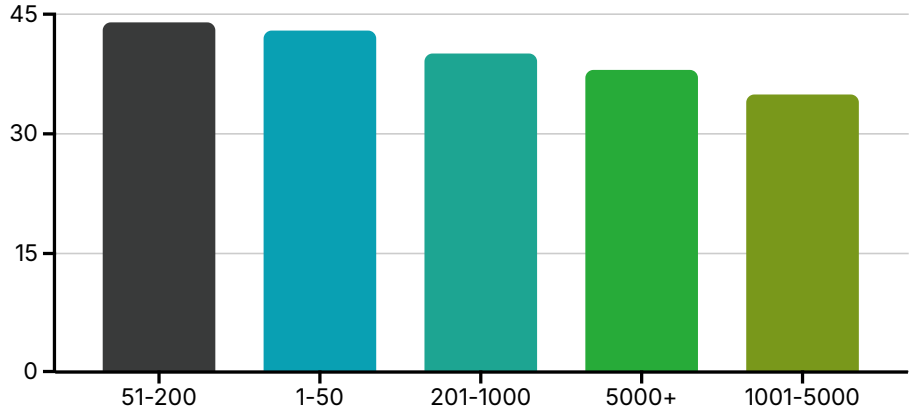
Use Case Benefits: Complete Breakdown

Primary Benefit	Count	% of Cases	Measured By	Average Benefit
Time Savings	1,760	34.3%	Hours/week	7.5 hours (median: 4.0)
Quality Improvement	771	15.0%	Percentage	38% (median: 30%)
Increased Output	730	14.2%	Percentage	41% (median: 30%)
New Capabilities	637	12.4%	Qualitative	Speed/scale (15%), New insights (14%), Personalization (12%)
Improved Decision Making	459	9.0%	Percentage	39% (median: 30%)
Cost Savings	377	7.4%	Percentage	43% (median: 33%)
Increased Revenue	206	4.0%	Percentage	19% (median: 10%)
Risk Reduction	184	3.7%	Qualitative	Early warning (20%), Error catching (19%), Compliance (10%)

Qualitative benefits reveal fascinating patterns: New Capabilities focus on enabling previously impossible tasks, while Risk Reduction emphasizes proactive prevention rather than reactive fixes. The shift from "how fast can we do this?" to "what can we now do?" marks the maturation of AI adoption.

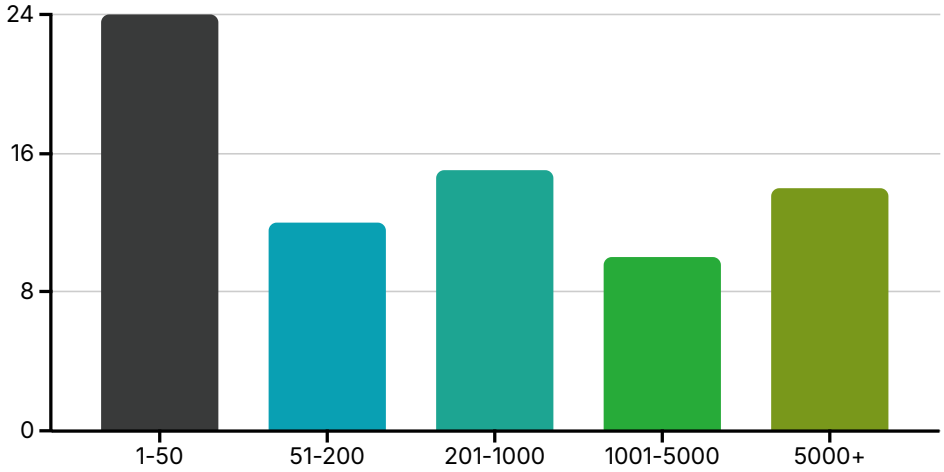
Output and Revenue: Company Size Patterns

Increased Output by Company Size



Smaller companies (1-200 employees) report higher output increases (~43-44%) than larger enterprises (~35-38%). This could be due to smaller teams seeing more concentrated impact, or less bureaucratic friction to adoption.

Increased Revenue by Company Size



Small companies with fewer than 50 employees enjoy 2X more AI-generated revenue increase (24%) than companies with 51-5,000 employees. This dramatic difference highlights the agility advantage.

Industry Variations Matter

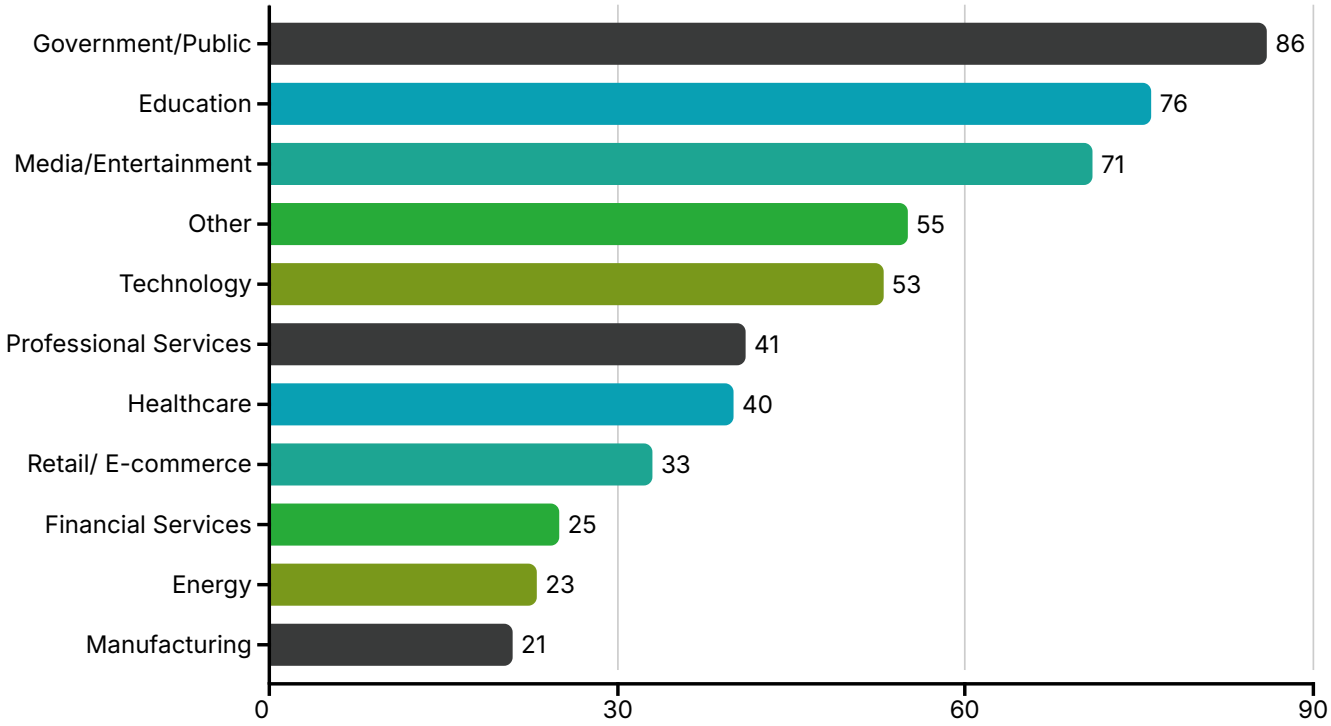
Media/Entertainment and Education see the highest output gains (50%+), while Financial Services and Healthcare are more conservative (~35%). Regulated industries face more constraints on AI-driven process changes.

The Mid-Size Challenge

Mid-sized companies (1,001-5,000 employees) often report the lowest gains—possibly the "awkward middle" where they're too big for quick wins but lack enterprise-scale resources.

6. Government/ public sector, Education, and Media/ Entertainment industries enjoy the highest overall composite value from AI

To check if some industries already reap greater benefits than others from AI, we conducted a composite benefit analysis across all metrics. The results reveal surprising patterns that challenge conventional assumptions about AI adoption.



> Knowledge-intensive sectors (Government, Education, Media) are reporting 2-3x higher composite benefits than process/regulation-heavy sectors (Financial Services, Manufacturing, Healthcare). The average compound benefit is 48.

The benefits that differentiate the most between industries are "Improved Decision Making" and "Increased Output." This suggests that sectors dealing primarily with information and communication can more easily integrate AI into core workflows, while industries with physical products, regulatory constraints, or legacy systems face additional implementation challenges.

7. Digging deeper into the use cases reported reveals key patterns of AI usage

To understand the nature of the reported use cases, we used an AI model to cluster and label each use case into 11 different groups. This classification reveals where AI is making the most impact and which applications are driving the highest value. The top three clusters account for 55%+ of all use cases: Content/Communications, Code/Software Development, and Customer/Sales.

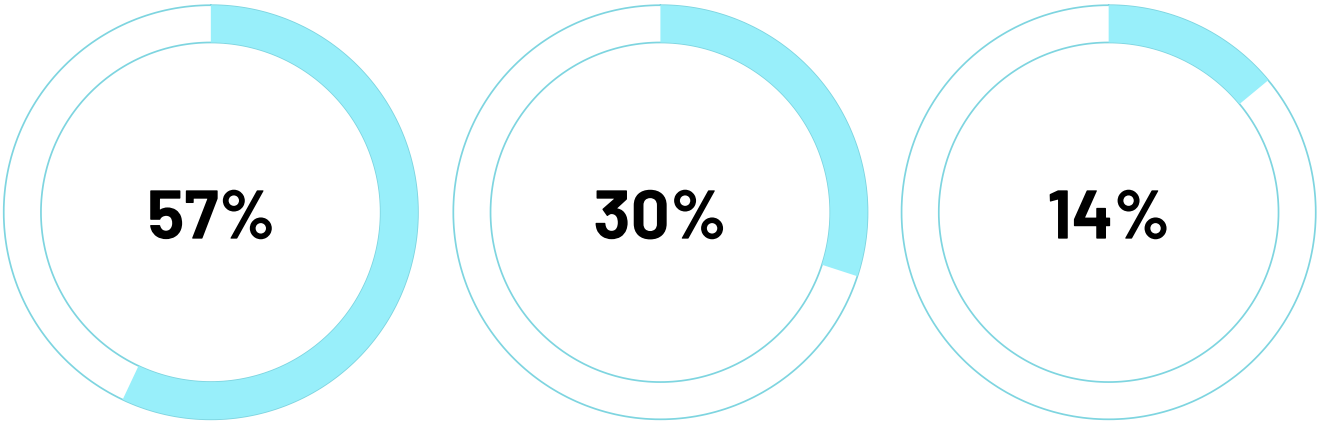
Cluster	%	Top Benefit (avg.)	Time Savings	Cost Savings	Quality Imp.
Content & Communications	25.3%	Time (6.7h)	6.7h	49%	40%
Code & Software Development	19.6%	Time (8.4h)	8.4h	60%	36%
Other	13.8%	Time (6.3h)	6.3h	44%	42%
Customer, Sales & Marketing	10.5%	Time (9.3h)	9.3h	33%	43%
Data & Analytics	8.9%	Time (8.3h)	8.3h	35%	45%
Document, Legal & Compliance	5.4%	Time (9.2h)	9.2h	43%	29%
HR, Recruiting & Learning	5.0%	Time (7.7h)	7.7h	45%	39%
Operations & Supply Chain	3.6%	Time (11.9h)	11.9h	20%	25%
Research & Strategy	3.4%	Time (7.4h)	7.4h	28%	36%
Finance & Accounting	2.5%	Time (9.1h)	9.1h	28%	33%
Creative, Design & Localization	2%	New Capab.	7.7h	18%	38%

Key insights:

1. **Time Savings dominates** as the top benefit for 10 of 11 clusters (only Creative/Design leads with New Capabilities)
2. **Highest time savings:** Operations & Supply Chain (11.9h) - likely automating complex logistics/planning tasks
3. **Highest cost savings:** Code & Software Dev (60%) - replacing expensive dev resources/tools
4. **Highest decision making improvement:** HR, Recruiting & Learning (48%) - AI helping with candidate evaluation, performance analysis
5. **Highest revenue impact:** Content & Communications (26%) - likely marketing/sales content driving conversions
6. **Operations oddity:** Lowest percentage-based benefits but highest time savings - suggests AI handles time-intensive but not percentage-impactful tasks there

8. AI Autonomy Levels: Agents Remain Nascent

We used an AI model to classify each use case by autonomy level. The results provide crucial context for understanding where AI adoption actually stands today versus the excitement around "autonomous agents."



Assisted AI
Human using AI tool manually

Automation AI
Managing entire workflows

Agentic AI
Autonomous work execution

Understanding the Categories

Assisted AI (56.6%)

The dominant mode of AI today. Examples include "Drafting emails," "Summarizing a PDF," or "Asking ChatGPT to debug code." The human initiates every single interaction. This is where most organizations start and many remain.

Automation AI (29.6%)

Substantial at ~30% of use cases. Includes workflows, pipelines, scripts, or processes. This segment represents meaningful productivity gains through systematic integration of AI into business operations.

Agentic AI (13.8%)

Surprisingly high at nearly 14%, though likely includes some "hype inflation" where complex scripts are labeled "agents." Examples include swarms of agents, end-to-end code generation, or autonomous performance review systems.

Autonomy Patterns Across Organizations

The Mid-Market Sweet Spot

Organizations with 51-200 employees have the highest rate of Agentic AI (17.6%) and Automation AI (33.5%). Why? They are big enough to have complex workflows that need automating, but small enough to lack the bureaucratic red tape that stops a "rogue agent" from being deployed.

VP-Level Drives Automation

VP-Level respondents report the highest usage of Agentic AI (19.7%). Individual Contributors are the most manual, with 58.7% Assisted AI. This pattern makes sense: ICs are often the "human in the loop" executing work, whereas VPs are designing systems to replace that work.

Industry Variations

Healthcare (18.2% Agentic) and Financial Services (18.2% Agentic) are the top adopters of autonomous agents. This is fascinating because these are highly regulated industries. It implies that "Agents" in these sectors are likely highly specialized, compliance-checking bots.

1

Education: Most Manual

71.6% Assisted AI—teachers and students using AI as tutor/copilot rather than automating learning

2

Media: Human-Led

64.4% Assisted—creative workers prefer staying in the driver's seat

3

Large Enterprises: Polarized

High Agentic (16.7%) but lowest Automation (25.4%)—skipping the middle step

9. Generic Tools Get Generic Results

To check the relationship between use cases and specific AI tools, we did a text analysis to identify which tools were mentioned and what benefits are associated with them. Only 744 use cases (14.5% of total) explicitly mentioned specific tools, suggesting most organizations use generic platforms.

Tool	n	Time	New Cap	Quality	Output	Decision	Cost	Revenue
ChatGPT	322	31.4%	17.4%	15.8%	10.2%	12.4%	6.5%	3.1%
Claude	163	33.7%	19.6%	12.3%	16.6%	8.0%	5.5%	2.5%
Copilot	112	48.2%	8.0%	12.5%	23.2%	3.6%	0.9%	3.6%
Gemini	90	34.4%	16.7%	10.0%	17.8%	6.7%	7.8%	2.2%
Cursor	46	30.4%	28.3%	8.7%	26.1%	4.3%	2.2%	0.0%
Perplexity	26	46.2%	11.5%	3.8%	11.5%	19.2%	0.0%	7.7%

> If you only deploy ChatGPT Enterprise, you will only get "better emails." Transformational ROI (Revenue/Cost) requires building custom solutions, not just buying licenses.

ChatGPT dominates time savings and decision-making use cases. Cursor and Copilot excel at increasing output in software development. Industry-specific tools drive cost savings and quality improvements in creative/design work. The pattern is clear: specialized tools for specialized outcomes.

The Discipline of Measurement Starts Now

This report is only the baseline. As 2026 approaches, the gap between organizations that merely "use" AI and those that measure and manage it will define market leadership. The data reveals clear patterns: small companies outperform large enterprises, strategic benefits outweigh efficiency gains, and specialized tools deliver transformational results.

81.8% Report Positive ROI Today

The value is real and measurable across industries

95.7% Expect Positive ROI in 12 Months

Momentum is accelerating, not slowing

Move Beyond Time Savings

Strategic benefits drive transformational returns

Build Your Portfolio

Multiple use cases compound value exponentially

The organizations winning with AI aren't waiting for perfect measurement frameworks—they're building them through practice. They're moving upstream from efficiency to strategy, diversifying their AI portfolio, and integrating specialized tools into workflows. Most importantly, they're measuring everything they can and iterating based on results.

Don't fly blind. Join AIDB Intelligence to benchmark your organization against peers, contribute your data, and access continuous, real-time insights on how the world's best companies are driving actual value from AI.

Get Your Benchmark at AIDB Intelligence